

CAUGHT IN THE ACT

Gupta is not the first to be nabbed. The history of counter-espionage is littered with many hits and misses.

HONEYTRAPS ▼

MANMOHAN SHARMA (2008)

R&AW official working at the Indian Embassy in Beijing was involved with a Chinese interpreter believed to be working for Chinese authorities. He was called back.



BRIGADIER UJJWAL DASGUPTA AND CDR MUKUL SAINI (2006)

Both R&AW officials who were working with the Indo-US cybersecurity forum. Dasgupta was compromised by CIA mole Rosanna Minchew. Still in prison.



RATTAN SEHGAL (1997)

Special Director of the Intelligence Bureau and the head of its counter-intelligence division was

filmed with US agents in Delhi. Sehgal was asked to leave.

K.V. UNNIKRISHNAN (1986)

R&AW official, heading the Chennai office of the agency, developed a relationship with an airhostess allegedly working for the CIA.

DEFECTOR ▼



RABINDER SINGH (2004)

Singh was a joint director in charge of the South East Asian Desk of the R&AW. Worked for the CIA.

Defected to the US via Nepal after being put under surveillance.

SPY RING ▼



COOMMAR NARAIN (1985)

The manager of the Maneklal Group, Narain was selling military secrets to many European embassies

through 15 government officials including the personal aide to P.C. Alexander, the then principal secretary to Rajiv Gandhi.

by Sandeep Unnithan



Rana, 40, a Pakistani major, at a dinner. He described himself as a local businessmen and reportedly a physical relationship followed. In addition, she received expensive gifts and regular cash payments from him. This was aided by constant ego-boasts, as he would praise her professional skills.

In the months that followed, Gupta became an integral part of Pakistan intelligence's operation that infiltrated deep inside the Indian mission. She contacted her handlers through 'dead drops' at secret locations, often wrapped in a newspaper at a park near a posh local market, Jinnah Super, and at the F-7 locality. She also used a string of e-mail accounts—'maddyg' and 'madsmiles' to name a few—to send messages to her handlers. Sources reveal that Indian intelligence agencies picked up her trail accidentally while tracking an Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) operative, a woman from Rajouri, Jammu and Kashmir, who was a frequent visitor to Pakistan. The ISI operative is still at large, but sources reveal that she was in touch with Gupta and the two also met regularly at an Islamabad shopping centre and spoke over the phone, which provided the first lead to Indian agencies.

Her other tactical mistake was an e-mail she sent to her contact from an office computer that led to an operation to trap her. But she told inter-

rogators that the senior officials in the Indian mission bossed around the juniors and she "wanted to teach these IFS officers a lesson". She claimed that she wanted to prove that despite their higher rank and privileges, they were not able to detect her operation. She was working in the High Commission as an interpreter, her primary job to scan the Urdu press and translate the reports. She was an attaché when she went to Pakistan three years ago but was promoted last year to second secretary.

Of greater concern is growing speculation that Gupta had befriended R.K. Sharma, an Indian Police Service officer and station chief of the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW). She used her contact with him to pass on sensitive information. But while officials involved in the investigations claim that she was a lone operator, sources confirm that Sharma was called to Delhi a while back and quizzed on his liaisons by senior officials. While Gupta was being interrogated, she is believed to have dropped a bombshell, naming another senior intelligence official who left the mission last year, "Why don't you question him?" Moreover, identities of another R&AW official, who was actually tasked to keep a watch on her, along with another intelligence officer from the cultural wing have been compromised. Left with